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ACADEMIC VAULT

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Entrepreneurship for Students: From Idea to First Paying Customer

Validate a business idea cheaply before you spend money on it

MONEY & CAREER

Money & Career

General Studies (GST / CED)
Centre for Entrepreneurship Development (CED) | 100L

Written for students, by students.

Practical notes, worked examples, practice questions and a revision plan.

Study smarter. Ask better questions. Pass with understanding.

Independent study support | Not an official UNIZIK publication

START HERE

Why this pack exists

Most student businesses fail because nobody wanted the product, not because the owner lacked passion. This pack teaches problem-first thinking, cheap validation, unit economics and a first-sale plan, with Nigerian campus examples you can test within a week.

This is a student-written study companion, not a reproduced lecture handout or a leaked examination paper. Use it to organise the topics you are taught, practise the kind of thinking your course rewards, and walk into class with better questions.

What you will be able to do

- Identify a real problem and define a specific customer.
- Validate demand before investing capital.
- Calculate simple unit economics and a break-even point.
- Plan and execute a first sale, then decide whether to continue.

How to use this pack

1. Skim the whole pack once in 20 minutes so you know what is inside.
2. Work through one section at a time with your lecture note and recommended text beside you.
3. Attempt the practice questions before reading the answers. Mark what you missed.
4. Use the final checklist to plan your revision week, one tick per study session.

> **Confirm your official course outline**
> Course codes, credit units and outlines can differ by department and session. Treat this pack as supplementary support and confirm the current outline with your lecturer, course rep or departmental handbook before an assessment.

Start from a problem

A business exists to solve a problem someone will pay to remove.

- Define the customer narrowly: '200-level engineering students in hostels' rather than 'students'.
- Describe the problem in their words, not yours.
- Check whether they currently solve it and how much that costs them.
- Avoid ideas that rely on everyone adopting a new habit.
- Look for frequent, painful and urgent problems.
- Write one problem statement before writing a business plan.

Validate cheaply

Do not build first and ask later.

1. Talk to ten real potential customers without pitching.
2. Ask what they do now, what it costs and what frustrates them.
3. Offer a manual version of the service to three people for a small fee.
4. Record whether they pay, not whether they say it is a good idea.
5. Adjust the offer based on what they actually paid for.
6. Only buy stock or build a product after evidence of willingness to pay.

> **Compliments are not demand**
> 'That is a nice idea' costs nothing. Payment, a deposit or a pre-order is evidence.

Unit economics and the first sale

A business that loses money on every sale cannot grow out of the problem.

- Price minus variable cost equals contribution per unit.
- Calculate break-even: fixed costs divided by contribution per unit.
- Count your own time as a cost, even if you do not pay yourself yet.
- Start with a narrow offer and deliver it excellently.
- Collect feedback and one testimonial from the first customer.
- Decide honestly after 30 days: continue, adjust or stop.